

0.0.1 Vasettha

1. Thus was heard by me. At one time the Auspicious One was dwelling at Icchanangala in the Icchanangala Forest Grove. At that time many well-known wealthy brahmins were dwelling at Icchānangala, such as: the brahmin Canki, the brahmin Tarukkha, the brahmin Pokkharasati, the brahmin Janussoṇi, the brahmin Todeyya, and many other well-known and wealthy brahmins.

2. Then brahmin youths Vasettha and Bharadvaja while walking and wandering about, walking along back and forth, this talk arose between them: “How indeed is one a brahmin?” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja said thus: “So far as, dear Sir, one is well borne, of pure descent from both the maternal and paternal sides as far back as seven generations, unblemished and irreproachable with regard to ancestry, it is to this extent, dear Sir, that one is a brahmin.” The brahmin youth Vasettha said thus: “So far as, dear Sir, one is virtuous and excels in religious duties, it is to this extent, dear Sir, that one is a brahmin.” Neither was the brahmin youth Bharadvaja able to convince the brahmin youth Vasettha, nor was the brahmin youth Vasettha able to convince the brahmin youth Bharadvaja.

3. So then, brahmin youth Vasettha address the brahmin youth, Bharadvaja. Master Bharadvaja, there is

this samana Gotama, son of the Sakyans who has gone forth from the Sakyan clan, dwelling at Icchanangala in the Icchanangala Forest Grove. Now a good reputation has been spread about that Auspicious Gotama thus: “Truly is he the Auspicious One, the Arahant, rightly self-awakened, excelling in knowledge and conduct, well-farer, knower of worlds, incomparable charioteer of tamed persons, teacher of devas and humans, awakened, auspicious.” We must visit with the samana Gotama, O Master Bharadvaja. Upon arrival, we must ask the samana Gotama about this matter. In which ever way the samana Gotama will answer, in just that way we must bear it in mind.”

4. So then, the brahmin youths Vasettha and Bharadvaja visited with the Auspicious One. Having approached, they exchanged friendly greetings with the Auspicious One. Having exchanged friendly greetings and cordial talk, they sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the brahmin youth Vasettha addressed the Auspicious One in verse:

We are accepted and acknowledged,
as triple knowledge masters;
I am Pokkharasāti’s student,
and this is Tārukkha’s student.

Of the three knowledges which are declared,
there is perfection [by us];

from its etymology and grammar,
we are equal to our teachers in recitation.

For us in regard to ancestry,
there is a dispute, O Gotama;
one is a brahmin by birth,
Bharadvaja speaks thus;
but I say by kamma,
know thus, O One Endowed with Eyes.

We are both unable,
to convince one another;
we have come to question the Auspicious One,

the Awakened One renowned as such.

As the newly formed waxing moon,
people worship with hands in anjali;
they paying homage to the moon,
so in the world is Gotama;
the eye arisen in the world,
we ask you Gotama.

Is one a brahmin by birth,
or by kamma;
tell us, we who do not know,
how we may know a brahmin.

For you, I will distinguish,
one and the other because of their species;

the analysis of birth of living beings,
in sequence as it truly is.

Know that the grass and trees,
even though [their birth] is not acknowledged;

their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

Next the moths and grasshoppers,
up to the biting insects and ants;
their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

Know the four footed too,
among the small and the large;
their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

Know those that crawl with their stomachs
too,
serpents, long backed crawlers;
their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

Next know from the fishes in water too,
with water as their pasture;
their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

Next know from the birds too,
with wings as vehicles, going by the sky;
their characteristics are made from birth,
one and the other because of their species.

As among these species,
there are various characteristics made from
 birth;
these various characteristics made from birth,
do not exist among humans.

Neither by head hairs nor by head,
neither by ear nor by eyes;
neither by face nor by nose,
neither by mouth nor by eyebrows.

Neither by neck nor by shoulder,
neither by stomach nor by back;
neither by waist nor by breast,
neither by genitals nor by mating.

Neither by hands nor by feet,
neither by fingers nor by nails;
neither by calf nor by thigh,
neither by color nor by voice;
certainly there are no characteristics made
 from birth,
as in the case of other species.

But among the bodies of individuals,

this [difference] among humans is not to be
 found;
 but characteristics among humans,
 are for the sake of designation, it is said.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
 lives in dependence on cow-keeping;
 know him thus, O Vasettha,
 he is a farmer, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
 lives in dependence on the various kind of
 crafts;
 know him thus, O Vasettha,
 he is a craftsman, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
 lives in dependence on trade;
 know him thus, O Vasettha,
 he is a merchant, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
 lives in dependence on serving others;
 know him thus, O Vasettha,
 he is a servant, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
 lives in dependence on what is not given;
 know him thus, O Vasettha,
 he is a thief, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
lives in dependence on shooting arrows;
know him thus, O Vasettha,
he is a soldier, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
lives in dependence on the office of chief priest;

know him thus, O Vasettha,
he is a sacrificing priest, not a brahmin.

Indeed, whoever among humans,
enjoys [the revenue] from the nation and its
villages;
know him thus, O Vasettha,
he is a king, not a brahmin.

But I do not call him a brahmin,
born of a womb, begotten from a mother;
he is called a sir-sayer,
if he owns something;
owning nothing, a disowner,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who, having cut all fetters,
is truly not perturbed;
who is detached with all bonds surmounted,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who having cut delight and the thong,

the tether together with the reins;
 the awakened one who has raised the cross
 bar,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

He who is not offended but forbears,
 abusive speech, beating and binding;
 the powerful one with the strength of patience,

 it is him I call a brahmin.

The one endowed with conduct, not inclined
 to anger,
 endowed with virtue, not arrogant;
 tamed, bearing his final body,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

Like water on lotus leaf,
 like mustard seed on a needle tip;
 who is not smeared in sensual pleasures,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

He who wisely understands suffering,
 has obliterated it right here by himself;
 who has put down the burden, detached,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

The wise one with deep wisdom,
 the expert of the path and the non-path;
 one attained to the supreme goal,

it is him I call a brahmin.

He who mixes neither with householders,
nor homeless ones alike;
roaming without abode, with fewness of wishes,

it is him I call a brahmin.

Having layed aside the rod among living beings,
both the frail and the firm;
who neither kills nor cause to kill,
it is him I call a brahmin.

unobstructed among those obstructed,
extinguished in the taking up of sticks;
a disowner among owners,
it is him I call a brahmin.

For whom lust and hate,
conceit and denigration are laid down;
like mustard seed on a needle tip,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who utters truthful words,
not harsh, conveying the meaning;
who does not abuse anyone,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who does not take what is not given in the

world,
whether long or short;
small or big, beautiful or ugly;
it is him I call a brahmin.

For whom hope is not to be found,
in this world and in the other;
hopeless and detached,
it is him I call a brahmin.

For whom reliance is not to be found,
having known, without perplexity;
attained to firm footing in the deathless,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who here merit and demerit,
attachment to both he has overcome;
sorrowless, stainless, pure,
it is him I call a brahmin.

Like the moon unblemished, pure,
clear and lucid;
with delight for being wholly obliterated,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who has transcended this wandering on in
delusion,
an obstruction so hard to penetrate;
the meditator who has crossed and gone be-
yond,

unperturbed without perplexity;
without undertakings, fully quenched,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who having abandoned sensual pleasures
here,
wanders about homeless;
with delight for sensual pleasures wholly obliterated,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who having abandoned thirsting here,
wanders about homeless;
thirsting in being wholly obliterated,
it is him I call a brahmin.

Having abandoned the human bondage,
he has overcome the celestial bondage;
detached from all bondages,
it is him I call a brahmin.

Having abandoned delight and discontent,
he has become cool, without belongings;
the hero who has conquered all the worlds,
it is him I call a brahmin.

He who knows death of beings,
and all their arisings;
unattached, well-fared, awakened,
it is him I call a brahmin.

For he who devas, ghandhabbas and human
 beings,
 cannot understand his destiny;
 The asava-free, the arahant,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

For he who after and before,
 and in-between there is not something;
 owning nothing, a disowner,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

The chief bull, the most excellent hero,
 the great seer, victorious;
 the Buddha unperturbed, fully cleansed [with
 the inner] bathing,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

He who knows his former abodes,
 and sees the heavens and the lower worlds;
 then attained to the obliteration of birth,
 it is him I call a brahmin.

Truly this is a designation in the world,
 the assignment of name and clan;
 arisen according to common usage,
 it is assigned as so and so.

For a long time it has persisted,
 those entrenched in views, not understanding;
 from not understanding they declare to us,

one is a brahmin by birth.

Neither by birth is one a brahmin,
nor by birth is one not a brahmin;
by kamma is one a brahmin,
by kamma is one not a brahmin.

By kamma is one a farmer,
by kamma is one a craftsman;
by kamma is one a merchant,
by kamma is one a servant.

A thief too, one comes to be by kamma,
by kamma is one also a soldier;
by kamma is one a sacrificing priest,
a king too, one comes to be by kamma.

The wise ones see kamma,
in just this way as it has come to be;
the seers of precedent co-arising,
experts in the results of kamma.

By kamma the world keeps rolling,
by kamma the generations turn;
beings are bound by kamma,
like the linchpin of a travelling chariot.

By ardency in the life of purity,
by self-control and taming;
by this one is a brahmin,

this is the brahmin unsurpassed.

Endowed with the triple knowledges,
the peaceful one with renewal of being obliterated;
know him thus, O Vasettha,
as Brahma, the capable one who understands
discriminately.

5. When thus was said, the young brahmins Vasettha and Bharadvaja said this to the Auspicious One: “Excellent, O Bhante! Excellent, O Bhante! Just as, O Bhante, one might set upright what has been overturned, or open up what has been closed, or show a path to one who is lost, or bear an oil lamp in the darkness so that those with good eyesight can see forms, just so has the Dhamma been explained by the venerable Gotama in countless ways. We go, O Bhante, to the Auspicious Gotama, as refuge, and to the Dhamma, and to the Sangha of bhikkhus. May Master Gotama bear it in mind, that we are lay disciples who have gone for refuge from today for as long as life lasts.”